

IEP Terminology Glossary

Complete Plain Language Definitions — Laws, Roles, Boards, and Resources

Knowledge is power. Partnership is progress. Together — the IEP gets APPROVED.

How to Use This Glossary

Special education has its own language. This glossary covers three things you need to know: (1) the key legal terms and acronyms, (2) the roles of every person in the IEP process, and (3) the boards, councils, and agencies you can contact when you need help. Use this as your reference guide before and after every meeting.

SECTION 1: KEY LAWS & LEGAL TERMS

ADA

Americans with Disabilities Act

A federal civil rights law prohibiting discrimination against people with disabilities in schools, workplaces, and public places. In schools, it ensures students with disabilities have equal access to programs and activities even if they do not have an IEP.

■ 42 U.S.C. § 12101

ESY

Extended School Year

Special education services provided beyond the regular school year — typically summer — when a child's IEP team determines the child would significantly regress without continued services. Schools cannot limit ESY to specific disability categories or claim budget constraints as a reason to deny it.

■ IDEA 34 CFR § 300.106

■ Who to contact: Your child's special education teacher or case manager to request an ESY evaluation

FAPE

Free Appropriate Public Education

The cornerstone right under IDEA. Every eligible child with a disability has the right to receive special education and related services at no cost to the family. "Appropriate" means reasonably calculated to enable the child to make meaningful progress — not the absolute best education possible, but a genuinely beneficial one.

■ 20 U.S.C. § 1401(9)

FERPA

Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act

A federal law that gives parents the right to access, review, and request corrections to their child's educational records. Schools cannot share your child's records without your consent. When your child turns 18, these rights transfer to the student.

■ *20 U.S.C. § 1232g*

■ Who to contact: Your school's registrar or principal to access records

IDEA

Individuals with Disabilities Education Act

The primary federal law governing special education in the United States. IDEA guarantees eligible children with disabilities the right to a free appropriate public education in the least restrictive environment. It covers children from birth through age 21 and establishes all IEP requirements, timelines, and procedural safeguards.

■ *20 U.S.C. § 1400 et seq.*

IEP

Individualized Education Program

A written legal document developed by a team — including parents — that outlines your child's current performance levels, annual goals, services to be provided, accommodations, and how progress will be measured. Must be reviewed at least annually. You must consent before services begin.

■ *20 U.S.C. § 1414(d)*

■ Who to contact: Your child's case manager or special education coordinator

LRE

Least Restrictive Environment

The legal requirement that children with disabilities be educated alongside children without disabilities to the maximum extent appropriate. Removal from general education classes should occur only when the nature of the disability is such that education in regular classes with supplementary aids and services cannot be achieved satisfactorily.

■ *IDEA 34 CFR § 300.114*

MTSS

Multi-Tiered System of Supports

A framework of increasing levels of support provided to all students based on their needs. Tier 1 is universal instruction for all students. Tier 2 is targeted support for students who need more. Tier 3 is intensive

individualized support. MTSS data is often used to identify students who may need a special education evaluation.

- Who to contact: Your child's general education teacher or school counselor

PWN

Prior Written Notice

A written notice the school must provide to parents a reasonable time before it proposes or refuses to make any change to your child's identification, evaluation, educational placement, or provision of FAPE. PWN must explain what the school proposes or refuses, why, what alternatives were considered, and what data supports the decision. Always request PWN in writing when the school makes any significant decision.

- *IDEA 34 CFR § 300.503*

- Who to contact: Your special education director if PWN is not provided

RTI

Response to Intervention

A process schools use to provide support to struggling students before referring them for special education evaluation. RTI data documents what interventions were tried and how the student responded. Schools sometimes use RTI improperly to delay special education evaluations — if you believe your child needs an evaluation, you can request one directly regardless of where they are in the RTI process.

- *34 CFR § 300.307*

Section 504

Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act

A civil rights law that prohibits discrimination against students with disabilities in programs receiving federal funding. Students who do not qualify for an IEP under IDEA may still be eligible for a 504 Plan with accommodations. A 504 Plan does not provide specialized instruction — it provides access and accommodations.

- *29 U.S.C. § 794*

- Who to contact: Your school's 504 coordinator

SECTION 2: IEP PROCESS & EVALUATION TERMS

AT / Assistive Technology

Any device, equipment, or software that helps a child with a disability participate more fully in education. Examples include communication devices (AAC), text-to-speech software, adaptive keyboards, hearing loops, and wheelchairs. The IEP team must consider whether your child needs AT.

■ *IDEA 34 CFR § 300.105*

■ Who to contact: Your district's Assistive Technology Specialist — every district must have one

BIP

Behavior Intervention Plan — A written plan addressing challenging behaviors. Identifies the function of the behavior and provides specific strategies to replace it with positive alternatives. Required when behavior impedes learning.

■ *IDEA 34 CFR § 300.324*

■ Who to contact: Your child's special education teacher or school psychologist

FBA

Functional Behavior Assessment — An evaluation that identifies WHY a challenging behavior occurs (the function). Results are used to develop a BIP. Schools must conduct an FBA before changing placement for disciplinary reasons.

■ *IDEA 34 CFR § 300.530*

■ Who to contact: School psychologist or behavior specialist

IEE

Independent Educational Evaluation — An evaluation by a qualified examiner NOT employed by the school district. You have the right to request an IEE at public expense if you disagree with the school's evaluation. The district must either fund the IEE or file for due process to defend its evaluation.

■ *IDEA 34 CFR § 300.502*

■ Who to contact: Special education director — submit your request in writing

PLAAFP

Present Levels of Academic Achievement and Functional Performance — The section of the IEP that describes how your child is currently performing. This is the baseline from which all annual goals are developed. If the PLAAFP is inaccurate, the goals will be wrong. Review it carefully.

■ *IDEA 34 CFR § 300.320(a)(1)*

Procedural Safeguards

A document schools must provide to parents explaining all your legal rights under IDEA — including the right to participate in IEP meetings, access records, request evaluations, and seek dispute resolution. Schools must give this to you at least once per year and upon initial referral.

■ *IDEA 34 CFR § 300.504*

Transition Services

A coordinated set of activities designed to help students move from school to post-secondary education, employment, and independent living. Must begin no later than the first IEP in effect when the student turns 16. Many states require planning to begin at age 14.

■ *IDEA 34 CFR § 300.43*

■ Who to contact: Your child's transition coordinator or case manager

SECTION 3: WHO DOES WHAT — ROLES IN THE IEP PROCESS

Every person at the IEP table has a specific role and responsibility. Knowing who does what helps you ask the right questions to the right people.

Case Manager / Special Education Case Coordinator

Your primary point of contact for all IEP matters. Coordinates the IEP team, schedules meetings, tracks services, and communicates between general and special education. If you have a question about your child's IEP, start here.

■ Ask them: Is the IEP being implemented as written? When is the next review? What data is being collected on goals?

Special Education Teacher (SPED Teacher)

Provides specially designed instruction to your child, either in a resource room, inclusion setting, or self-contained classroom. Writes IEP goals in collaboration with the team and tracks progress.

■ Ask them: What does my child's daily schedule look like? How is progress on goals being measured? What strategies work best for my child?

General Education Teacher

Required member of the IEP team. Responsible for implementing accommodations and modifications in the general education classroom. Must be knowledgeable about your child's IEP.

■ Ask them: Are you implementing all accommodations as written? How is my child doing socially in the classroom?

School Psychologist

Conducts psychological and educational evaluations, including cognitive assessments, behavior evaluations, and FBAs. Interprets evaluation data for the IEP team. Does NOT provide ongoing therapy in most districts.

■ Ask them: Can you explain the evaluation results in plain language? What do the scores mean for my child's education?

Speech-Language Pathologist (SLP)

Evaluates and provides services for communication disorders including speech articulation, language comprehension and expression, fluency, and social communication. Also supports students who use AAC

(augmentative and alternative communication) devices.

■ **Ask them: What communication goals are you targeting? How can I support speech goals at home?**

Occupational Therapist (OT)

Addresses fine motor skills, sensory processing, handwriting, self-care skills, and the ability to participate in school activities. Provides services when these areas affect educational performance.

■ **Ask them: What sensory supports does my child need in the classroom? How are you addressing handwriting or self-care goals?**

Physical Therapist (PT)

Addresses gross motor skills, mobility, posture, and physical access to the educational environment. Works with students who have physical disabilities or conditions affecting movement.

■ **Ask them: Is my child able to access all areas of the school safely? What equipment does my child need?**

School Counselor

Provides social-emotional support, crisis intervention, and college/career planning. Can be an advocate within the school system and a resource for connecting families to outside services. Not the same as a therapist — they provide short-term support, not ongoing treatment.

■ **Ask them: What social-emotional supports are available for my child? Can you help connect us to community resources?**

LEA Representative (Local Educational Agency Rep)

A required member of every IEP team. Must be a qualified school official authorized to commit district resources. Often the special education director, assistant principal, or designated administrator. This person can say yes to services — make sure they are present and engaged.

■ **Ask them: Are you authorized to commit district resources today? What is the district's position on [specific service]?**

Behavior Specialist / Board Certified Behavior Analyst (BCBA)

Conducts behavior assessments and designs behavior intervention plans. Trained in Applied Behavior Analysis (ABA). Not present at all IEP meetings — typically involved when behavior is a significant concern.

■ Ask them: What is the function of my child's challenging behavior? What replacement behaviors are being taught?

Assistive Technology Specialist

Evaluates students' needs for assistive technology and recommends devices and software. Must be considered by every IEP team. If your child struggles with writing, communication, or accessing curriculum, request an AT evaluation.

■ Ask them: Has my child been evaluated for assistive technology? What devices or software might help?

Transition Coordinator

Supports students age 14+ (or 16+ in some states) in planning for post-secondary education, employment, and independent living. Connects families with vocational rehabilitation, adult services, and community resources.

■ Ask them: What post-secondary options should we be exploring? How do we connect with vocational rehabilitation?

Parent / Guardian

YOU. A required member of the IEP team with equal standing. You bring knowledge of your child that no professional in that room has. Your consent is required for evaluations, initial services, and significant placement changes. Your voice matters — use it.

■ Your role: Share what you observe at home. Ask questions until you understand. Don't sign anything you're not ready to agree to.

SECTION 4: BOARDS, COUNCILS & AGENCIES — WHO TO CONTACT AND FOR WHAT

When the IEP process breaks down, or when you need support beyond your child's school, these are the organizations, boards, and agencies you can turn to. Know them before you need them.

LEA — Local Educational Agency

Your school district. The LEA is legally responsible for ensuring your child receives FAPE. The Superintendent and Director of Special Education are the top officials.

When to use: File a formal complaint with the LEA in writing when the school is not implementing the IEP or is denying services.

■ *Contact: District Special Education Director — find them on your district's website*

SEA — State Educational Agency

Your state's Department of Education. The SEA oversees all LEAs in the state, monitors compliance with IDEA, and investigates formal state complaints.

When to use: File a State Complaint when the district has violated IDEA and you want a formal investigation. The SEA must respond within 60 days.

■ *Contact: State Director of Special Education — find them at your state's Department of Education website*

Parent Training and Information Center (PTI)

Federally funded centers in every state that provide free training and information to parents of children with disabilities. PTI staff can help you understand your rights, prepare for IEP meetings, and navigate disputes. This is one of the most underused resources available to families.

When to use: Contact your PTI for free one-on-one support, workshops, and IEP preparation help.

■ *Contact: Find your state's PTI at parentcenterhub.org — completely free*

Protection and Advocacy Organization (P&A;)

Federally mandated organizations in every state that provide legal advocacy services to people with disabilities. P&A; organizations can advise you on your rights, help you navigate the IEP process, and in some cases provide legal representation.

When to use: Contact your P&A; when you face serious rights violations and need legal support.

■ *Contact: Find your state's P&A; at napas.org*

Office of Special Education Programs (OSEP)

The federal office within the U.S. Department of Education responsible for administering IDEA. OSEP publishes policy letters, guidance documents, and data on special education compliance across states.

When to use: Use OSEP's resources to understand federal policy and cite official guidance in disputes.

■ *Contact: ed.gov/about/offices/list/osep*

Office for Civil Rights (OCR)

The U.S. Department of Education office that enforces civil rights laws in education, including Section 504 and ADA. You can file a complaint with OCR if you believe your child has been discriminated against.

When to use: File an OCR complaint for civil rights violations — disability discrimination, retaliation, or failure to provide accommodations under 504/ADA.

■ *Contact: ocrcas.ed.gov — file online, free of charge*

State Vocational Rehabilitation (VR)

State agencies that provide employment-related services to people with disabilities, including job training, college support, assistive technology, and job coaching. Students should connect with VR before they leave high school.

When to use: Contact VR when your child is approaching transition age (14-16) to begin planning for employment and post-secondary education.

■ *Contact: Find your state VR agency at rsa.ed.gov/about/states*

State Developmental Disabilities Council (DD Council)

State councils that plan and advocate for policy changes to support people with developmental disabilities. DD Councils fund projects, provide grants, and advocate for systemic change. They can also connect families with local resources.

When to use: Contact your DD Council for information on state-funded programs, grants, and advocacy resources.

■ *Contact: Find your state's DD Council at acl.gov/programs/aging-and-disability-networks*

Disability Rights Organizations (DRO)

Nonprofit organizations that advocate for the rights of people with disabilities through education, community organizing, and legal action. Many provide free resources, workshops, and individual support to families.

When to use: Connect with your local DRO for community support, workshops, and advocacy resources.

■ *Contact: Search "disability rights [your state]" to find your local organization*

Special Education Advisory Committee (SEAC)

A required committee in every school district that advises the school board on special education matters. SEAC meetings are typically open to the public. Parents can attend, speak at meetings, and even serve on the committee.

When to use: Attend SEAC meetings to stay informed about district special education policies and raise concerns at the system level.

■ *Contact: Your district's special education office — ask when SEAC meetings are held*

School Board

The elected or appointed governing body of your school district. The school board sets policy and approves the budget, including special education funding. School board meetings are public — you have the right to speak during public comment.

When to use: Contact your school board when district-level policies are affecting your child's services, or when individual school complaints have not been resolved.

■ *Contact: Your district's website — school board meeting schedules and agendas are public record*

Medicaid / CHIP

Federal and state health insurance programs that may cover therapies, medical equipment, and other services your child needs. Schools can bill Medicaid for some services but cannot reduce IEP services because of Medicaid coverage.

When to use: Apply for Medicaid/CHIP if your child does not have private insurance — many therapies and AT devices can be covered.

■ *Contact: Your state's Medicaid office or [healthcare.gov](https://www.healthcare.gov)*

Remember: You Are Never Alone

IEP Approved exists because navigating this system should not require a law degree. Ask Ada any question at iepapproved.com — she knows the law, the process, and the resources available to your family. Free, always.